

Writing to influence

SOME TEXTS SEEK TO CHANGE AN AUDIENCE'S VIEWS OR BEHAVIOR.

Pieces of writing that argue or persuade seek to influence the audience. However, there are subtle differences between arguing and persuading.

A strong argument

An argument tends to acknowledge the opposite opinion while providing well-reasoned arguments against it. For example, if someone were to argue that cats were better than dogs, that person would not simply list all the good things about cats. He or she would acknowledge why some people prefer dogs, then argue against those points.

Reasons why people prefer dogs to cats

- Dogs are more intelligent than cats. Cats are smart enough to hunt, wash, and fend for themselves.
- Cats are unkind because they bring dead mice into the house. This is their way of showing affection.
- Cats are unsociable. They are friendly but don't demand constant attention—an annoying characteristic of dogs.

To plan an argument, list the reasons why people take the opposite point of view.

Try to disprove each point with a counterargument.

Powers of persuasion

A persuasive piece is more one-sided and emotional than an argument. It often coaxes the audience to act: for example, to buy a product, join an organization, or donate money to charity.

Persuasive writing does not accept the opposite opinion.

WHY WOULD YOU EVER WANT A CAT?



DOGS ARE FANTASTIC.



GET ONE TODAY!

This type of writing coaxes the reader to act now.

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- Persuasive writing should be firm but **not aggressive**.
- **Real-life stories** add emotion to a piece of writing.
- Use **confident language**, such as *you will* and *definitely*, rather than *you might* and *possibly*.

GLOSSARY

Exaggeration Representing something as larger or better than it actually is.

Hyperbole An extreme form of exaggeration that is not necessarily taken seriously, but grabs the reader's attention.

Rhetorical question A question that does not need an answer but is used for effect.

Superlative The form of an adjective or adverb that suggests the greatest or least of something.